



SHARE-A-PUNJAB

While political dynasties hand power from one generation to next, the Badals share it

| By Ramesh Vinayak |

Dynasties crop up in politics and ensure that power is handed down from one generation to the next. In Punjab, a new benchmark has been set by the state's first family—the Badals. Sukhbir Singh Badal's elevation as deputy chief minister in the Cabinet led by his father, Punjab Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal, has introduced the latest concept of power sharing: dividing the two top posts between themselves.

Ironically, the senior Badal was a one-time trenchant critic of the Gandhi family for its dynastic tradi-

tion. Sensing uncertainty about the outcome of the upcoming Lok Sabha elections in the face of a perceptible groundswell of anti-incumbency against the two-year-old Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD)-Bharatiya Janta Party (BJP) regime, and aware of the BJP high command's compulsion to keep his party in the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) fold, Badal was left with no choice but to anoint Sukhbir as his second-in-command. This move settled the succession issue in his own party as well as in the alliance once and for all. His gambit may have backfired as it has left the state BJP leaders

livid over being kept in the dark on what they derided as a "unilateral decision against the coalition dharma".

With Sukhbir's coronation, the Badals have consolidated their grip on the state's power politics—as the extended Badal family controls roughly one-third of 18 cabinet berths and two-thirds of ministerial portfolios. Sukhbir's swearing-in as Parkash's deputy has caused much consternation in the BJP and led to cracks in the alliance as Badal had doggedly spurned the saffron party's claim for the post. This, despite the fact that it is the first time in the his-